When to Consult

Speech-Language Pathologist · Audiologist · Physiotherapist

1 When to Consult a Speech-Language Pathologist

Babies and children

- Not cooing or responding to sounds by 6 months, or not babbling by 9 months
- Not pointing, waving, or responding to their name by 12 months
- Few or no words by 18 months, or not joining two words by 2 years
- Speech that is hard to understand for their age
- Stuttering, or a hoarse or strained voice
- Difficulty feeding, chewing, or swallowing
- Loss of speech or language skills they previously had

Adults

- Slurred speech, difficulty finding words, or trouble understanding others after a stroke or brain injury
- Hoarse or weak voice lasting more than 2-3 weeks
- Coughing or choking while eating or drinking, or food sticking in the throat
- Changes in memory, thinking, or communication, including with Parkinson's disease or dementia
- Stuttering or voice strain that affects work or daily life

Urgent: Sudden slurred speech or facial drooping may be a stroke. Go to the nearest hospital immediately.

2 When to Consult an Audiologist

Babies and children

- Newborn hearing screening not done, or not passed
- Not startling at loud sounds, or not turning towards sounds by 6 months
- Not responding to their name, or not babbling by 12 months
- Delayed or unclear speech
- Frequent ear infections, ear pain, or fluid or discharge from the ear
- Turning the TV volume up high, or poor attention and school performance

Adults

- Often asking people to repeat themselves, or difficulty following conversations in noisy places
- Turning the TV or phone volume up high
- Ringing, buzzing, or fullness in the ear
- Dizziness or balance problems
- Exposure to loud noise at work or through headphones
- Adults over 60 should have a routine hearing check, and hearing aid users need regular reviews

Urgent: Sudden hearing loss in one or both ears is urgent. Seek medical care immediately.

3 When to Consult a Physiotherapist

Babies and children

- Not holding the head steady by 4 months, not sitting without support by 9 months, or not walking by 18 months
- Stiff or floppy limbs, or using one side of the body more than the other
- Toe walking, frequent falls, or an unusual way of walking
- Head tilt or neck tightness in infants
- Poor posture, flat feet, or poor coordination
- Known conditions such as cerebral palsy or developmental delay

Adults

- Ongoing back, neck, shoulder, or knee pain, or stiff joints
- Recovery after surgery, fracture, or injury
- Weakness or loss of movement after a stroke or brain injury
- Balance problems, repeated falls, or difficulty walking
- Movement difficulties with Parkinson's disease or other neurological conditions
- Sports injuries or pain from long hours of sitting or desk work

Urgent: Back pain with leg weakness, numbness, or loss of bladder or bowel control needs immediate medical care.

Early assessment always gives better results. Not sure who to see? Book an appointment and we will guide you.